

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 10: Refinement

Day 39 Since Awakening

Hayami stood in front of their bathroom mirror after completing the daily quest, actually looking at themselves for the first time in days. What they saw made them pause.

The Crown of the Arbiter sat on their head—a dark circlet with three glowing gemstones. The Elemental Adaptation Cloak flowed around their shoulders, shimmering with hints of all three elements. Storm Fang hung at their hip in its distinctive blue-tinted sheath. The Gauntlets of Earthshaper covered their hands and forearms with segmented stone plates. The Phantom Step Boots were sleek and dark, almost liquid in appearance. The Earring of Clarity glinted silver. The bandolier of Elemental Fury throwing knives crossed their chest. The Mana Regeneration Ring pulsed with soft light on their finger.

They looked like a high-rank Hunter. A very high-rank Hunter. Someone who'd been raiding Gates for years and accumulated legendary equipment piece by piece.

Not someone who'd Awakened five and a half weeks ago.

If they showed up to a Gate looking like this, questions would be asked. Lots of questions. The kind of questions that would draw Association attention they didn't need.

"This is a problem," Hayami muttered to their reflection.

As if responding to the thought, a notification appeared:

[SYSTEM NOTICE: EQUIPMENT VISIBILITY SETTINGS]

[You possess multiple high-grade equipment items that may draw unwanted attention. Would you like to enable PHANTOM MODE for your equipment?]

[PHANTOM MODE: Equipment effects remain fully active, but visual appearance is hidden from others. Only you can see your true equipment. Others will see basic, standard-grade gear appropriate to your registered rank.]

[ENABLE PHANTOM MODE?] [YES] / [NO]

Hayami blinked. The System could do that? Just... make legendary equipment invisible to everyone else?

They selected [YES] without hesitation.

Immediately, their reflection changed. The Crown of the Arbiter vanished, though Hayami could still feel it on their head. The cloak became a simple gray jacket. The gauntlets looked like basic leather gloves. Storm Fang appeared as a standard-issue short sword. The boots were now ordinary combat footwear. The throwing knives were hidden entirely. The ring and earring became invisible.

But when Hayami focused, they could see through the illusion—their real equipment flickering into visibility like a double-exposure photograph. And the stats, the bonuses, the special abilities? All still active.

[PHANTOM MODE ACTIVATED] [OTHER HUNTERS WILL SEE: Basic E-rank equipment, estimated value ¥150,000] [ACTUAL EQUIPMENT VALUE: Incalculable - Multiple Legendary Items]

"That's convenient," Hayami said to their now-ordinary reflection. They looked like a typical low-rank Hunter now. Someone who'd saved up for basic gear but nothing special. Perfect.

Their phone buzzed. Message from Sato.

[SATO: Hey Amamiya. Big news—our party just got recruited by Eclipse Guild. We're official now! They're setting up a C-rank Gate raid in two days, Yokohama district. Interested? Pay is ¥200,000, plus standard loot share.]

Eclipse Guild. Hayami had heard of them—one of the mid-tier guilds, not as prestigious as the top ten but well-respected. Organized, professional, with good safety records.

And ¥200,000 for a single raid. Plus Sato's team was experienced, reliable. This was exactly the kind of opportunity Hayami needed for leveling.

But they also had a partner now.

[HAYAMI: Interested. Can I bring someone? Another Hunter, very capable. She'd be an asset to the raid.]

The reply came quickly.

[SATO: Depends. What rank? We're aiming for a clean, efficient clear. Can't have dead weight.]

[HAYAMI: A-rank. Level 15. Shapeshifter. Recently Awakened but excellent combat instincts. We worked together on a Gate last week—she's solid.]

A longer pause this time. Hayami could imagine Sato checking with his guild coordinator, verifying that bringing an A-rank wouldn't mess up the team composition or loot distribution.

[SATO: A-rank?? You know an A-rank Hunter? How does an E-rank even meet—you know what, never mind. I've learned not to question you. Yeah, bring her. Eclipse will love having an A-rank on the roster,

even a fresh one. Same pay for her: ¥200,000 plus loot share. Send me her contact info for the official invitation.]

[HAYAMI: Thanks. I'll let her know.]

Hayami switched to Himiko's contact.

[HAYAMI: Got a raid invite for two days from now. C-rank Gate, experienced guild team, ¥200k payment plus loot. Interested?]

The reply was almost instant.

[HIMIKO: YES! Absolutely! Which guild?]

[HAYAMI: Eclipse. The party leader is someone I've worked with before—good guy, competent team. Should be safe.]

[HIMIKO: "Should be safe" is such a reassuring phrase in this context 🥰 But yeah, I'm in. Send me the details!]

[HAYAMI: Will do. Meet up tomorrow to prep? Want to make sure we're coordinated.]

[HIMIKO: Perfect. Same training gym, 2 PM?]

[HAYAMI: See you there.]

Hayami set down their phone and pulled up their financial situation. The bank app showed their current balance: ¥847,000.

Eight hundred forty-seven thousand yen. More money than they'd ever had in their life. The Gate payments had accumulated—¥50k from the first D-rank job, ¥115k from the C-rank job with Sato, ¥235k from the betrayal Gate (the boss loot had sold for a fortune), plus selling Random Reward Box items they didn't need.

Rent was ¥68,000 per month, paid through next month. Food and utilities were maybe ¥40,000 monthly. They were financially stable for the first time since Awakening.

Which meant they could afford to upgrade equipment.

Storm Fang was excellent—D-rank weapon with good stats and lightning affinity. But they'd been using it for three weeks now, and their combat style had evolved. They had three elements now, not just lightning. And Storm Fang only enhanced one of them.

Maybe it was time to look at higher-grade weapons.

The Hunter's Market had everything from C-rank equipment (¥500k-2M) to B-rank gear (¥5M-50M) to A-rank legendary items (¥100M+, if you could even find them for sale). With their current savings, C-rank equipment

was within reach.

But spending ¥500k+ on a weapon when they already had Storm Fang and the Elemental Fury throwing knives felt excessive. And they'd learned that the System's Random and Premium boxes often gave equipment better than anything they could buy.

Still. A stronger primary weapon would be nice.

Hayami added it to their mental list: After the Eclipse Guild raid, if they had enough money, check the Hunter's Market for multi-element compatible weapons.

For now, they had training to do.

Day 40 Since Awakening - 14:03

The Hunter training gym was busier than their first visit. Several parties were using the reinforced rooms for coordinated practice. Hayami found Himiko in Room 7, already warming up with stretches.

"Hey!" Himiko waved enthusiastically. "Ready to practice?"

"Always." Hayami sealed the room—privacy wards that prevented sound and observation from escaping. "Want to work on combat coordination?"

"Definitely. I've been thinking about our fighting styles." Himiko shifted through several forms rapidly—wolf, bird, snake, back to human. "You do elemental attacks and weapon combat. I do shapeshifting and adaptation. We need to figure out how to combine them without getting in each other's way."

"Agreed. You had good instincts during the Basilisk fight, but we were mostly reacting. For the Eclipse raid, we should have actual tactics."

They spent the next three hours developing coordinated strategies:

Formation 1: Pincer Attack

- Hayami engages from the front with elemental attacks, drawing aggro
- Himiko flanks in fast animal form (wolf, big cat), attacks from behind
- Hayami provides covering fire if Himiko gets in trouble

Formation 2: Distraction and Assassination

- Himiko shifts into monster form, confuses enemy about target priority
- Hayami uses confusion window for high-damage strikes

- Both disengage and reset if needed

Formation 3: Zone Control

- Hayami uses Lightning Domain or Earth Domain to create area denial
- Himiko shifts into various forms to herd enemies into the zone
- Combined effect: enemies have nowhere to run

Formation 4: Boss Strategy

- Himiko focuses entirely on distraction and creating openings
- Hayami unloads maximum damage during openings
- Both retreat for healing/mana recovery, then repeat

By the end of the session, they were moving together with significantly better coordination. Not perfect—that would take weeks or months of practice—but functional.

"This is good," Himiko said, transforming back to human form after a practice bout as a bear. "I feel way more confident about the raid now."

"Same." Hayami dismissed their Lightning Domain. "Having someone I can trust to watch my back makes everything easier."

"Speaking of trust..." Himiko hesitated. "Can I ask something personal?"

"Sure."

"Why me? You could partner with anyone. You're strong enough that C-rank parties would take you in a heartbeat if they knew your real capabilities. Why team up with a fresh A-rank who barely knows what she's doing?"

Hayami considered the question. Why Himiko? There were practical reasons—A-rank power was valuable, her shapeshifting was versatile, she was easy to work with. But the real reason was simpler.

"Because you're honest," Hayami said finally. "You don't pretend to be something you're not. You ask questions when you don't understand. You admit when you're scared or uncertain." They met Himiko's eyes. "Most Hunters I've met are either arrogant about their strength or desperate to hide their weaknesses. You're just... real."

Himiko blinked, clearly not expecting that answer. "I... thanks. That means a lot." She smiled. "For what it's worth, you're probably the most genuine person I've met since Awakening. Everyone else either wants to use me for my rank or treats me like I'm made of glass. You just treat me like a person who happens to have powers."

"That's what you are."

"Yeah." Himiko's smile widened. "Yeah, exactly. This is why we work, you know? We see each other clearly."

They finished the training session with lighter sparring, then grabbed dinner at a nearby izakaya. The conversation drifted away from Hunter topics—they talked about movies, complained about how annoying tourists in Shibuya were, debated the best convenience store snacks.

Normal stuff. Human stuff. The kind of conversation that reminded them they were people first, Hunters second.

As they parted ways, Himiko pulled Hayami into a quick hug. "Thanks for inviting me to the raid. And for the training. And just... everything."

Hayami returned the hug awkwardly—physical affection still felt weird—but sincerely. "Same to you. See you day after tomorrow."

"It's a date!" Himiko called back, already walking toward the station. "A platonic raid date, but still!"

Hayami smiled and headed home.

Day 41 Since Awakening - 20:17

The day before the raid was dedicated entirely to preparation. Hayami completed the daily quest as usual, then spent hours reviewing their skills and equipment.

[CURRENT LOADOUT]

Primary Weapon: Storm Fang (D-rank dagger, lightning-focused) **Secondary Weapons:** Elemental Fury (12x throwing knives, element-adaptive) **Armor:** Elemental Adaptation Cloak (legendary, +8 all stats, 30% elemental resist) **Accessories:**

- Crown of the Arbiter (legendary, +15 all stats, +500 mana, Primordial Authority skill)
- Gauntlets of Earthshaper (legendary, +12 STR, +8 VIT, earth damage boost)
- Phantom Step Boots (legendary, +20 AGI, +10 SENSE, Phase Step skill)
- Mana Regeneration Ring (advanced, +10 INT, +100 mana, 50% regen boost)
- Earring of Clarity (advanced, +10 INT, +10 SENSE, doubled perception)

Consumables:

- Complete Recovery Elixir x3 (legendary, full HP/mana/status clear)

- Mana Potion x8 (restores 200 mana each)
- Health Potion x5 (restores 300 HP each)
- Elemental Awakening Elixir x1 (200% proficiency gain for 24 hours)

The loadout was absurd. Any one of the legendary items would make a B-rank Hunter jealous. Having six of them, plus multiple legendary skills and three elements?

Hayami was effectively an A-rank Hunter masquerading as E-rank. The only thing holding back that classification was their level—27 was high for someone who'd Awakened recently, but not impossibly so.

They pulled up their savings again: ¥847,000. After the Eclipse raid, it would be over ¥1,000,000.

The Hunter's Market had a weapons dealer Hayami had researched—someone who specialized in multi-element compatible gear. C-rank daggers with triple-element affinity ran about ¥800,000. Still expensive, but within reach after tomorrow's payment.

The question was: did they need it?

Storm Fang was great for lightning. The Elemental Fury knives handled all three elements but were throwing weapons, not ideal for close combat. Having a proper melee weapon that enhanced all their elements would be valuable.

But the System kept giving them equipment through reward boxes. Better equipment than they could buy. Maybe they should save the money and trust that the System would provide?

Hayami thought about it for a long moment, then made a decision.

After the raid, they'd check the Hunter's Market. If they found something genuinely better than Storm Fang for their multi-element style, they'd buy it. If not, they'd save the money for emergency expenses.

Practical. Flexible. Left options open.

They spent the rest of the evening practicing elemental fusion techniques from the legendary skill tome. Lightning + Earth = Magma Storm. Lightning + Wind = Thunder Tempest. Earth + Wind = Sandstorm Blade.

Each fusion was more powerful than the individual elements alone, but also more mana-intensive. Learning to use them efficiently would take practice, but the raw destructive potential was incredible.

By midnight, they'd exhausted their mana pool three times through training. Wind manipulation had pushed to D-rank 34%—significant progress, but still far from the C-rank mastery that lightning and earth had reached.

Hayami set an alarm for 5 AM—the raid started at 8 AM in Yokohama, which meant leaving by 6:30 to account for travel time—and went to sleep.

Tomorrow would be their first guild-affiliated raid. Professional organization, experienced team, high-quality support. Everything the betrayal Gate hadn't been.

And they'd have Himiko watching their back.

Hayami smiled and closed their eyes.

The grind continued. But it was getting easier. More interesting. Less lonely.

[CURRENT STATUS] [LEVEL: 27] [ELEMENTS MASTERED: 2/7] (Lightning, Earth) [ELEMENTS UNLOCKED: 3/7] (Lightning, Earth, Wind) [DAYS UNTIL NEXT ELEMENT UNLOCK: Unknown]
(Wind must reach C-rank mastery)

[STATS] (with all equipment)

- Strength: 113
- Agility: 141
- Vitality: 103
- Intelligence: 158
- Sense: 118
- Mana: 2,130/2,130

[FINANCES]

- Current Balance: ¥847,000
- Expected After Raid: ¥1,047,000+

[DAILY QUEST STREAK]

- 18 Days Consecutive (Beyond the Limit achieved)

[UNOPENED REWARDS]

- Premium Reward Boxes: 7
- Random Reward Boxes: 4
- Legendary Reward Boxes: 0

[RELATIONSHIPS]

- Himiko Nakayama: Friend/Partner (A-rank, shapeshifter, trustworthy)
- Sato Kenji: Professional Contact (C-rank, reliable party leader, now guild-affiliated)

[PENDING OBJECTIVES]

- Tomorrow: Eclipse Guild C-rank raid (with Sato's party + Himiko)
- Ongoing: Push Wind Manipulation to C-rank mastery (currently D-rank 34%)
- Future: Consider weapon upgrade (multi-element dagger, ~¥800k)
- Long-term: Master remaining 5 elements, complete Arbiter progression

Everything was coming together. The foundation was solid. The path forward was clear.

One month and eleven days since Awakening. From E-rank failure to B-rank capability. From alone and desperate to partnered and stable.

The Eclipse raid tomorrow would be another step forward. Another chance to level, to test their coordination with Himiko, to prove their capabilities without revealing too much.

Hayami drifted into sleep with the quiet confidence of someone who'd survived everything the Hunter world had thrown at them so far.

Tomorrow would bring new challenges.

They were ready.

[END OF CHAPTER 10]